

it. People were friendly, and when someone read John 3:16 and invited the audience to put their own name in the verse—"For God so loved Penny"—she felt something new and unknown stirring within her.

Penny and Suzanne returned to the church for several weeks, and soon both young women had accepted Christ as their Savior and made a commitment to live for Him. Penny quietly told her parents and some of her cousins and other relatives about her decision, but continued to attend her family's church on most Sundays, while going to the services at New Life on Saturdays. She believed that her family would be more amenable to hear about her new faith if they saw that it didn't pull her away from them.

One day the message at New Life was about how not only her life belonged to Christ, but so did her money and possessions. The thought that the Lord could be interested in everyday matters like money was a new one for her. The pastor mentioned a class in managing finances according to God's principles, and Penny signed up. Since she had never followed up with the debt counselor she had found online, instead putting off the problem to think about it another time, she decided she might as well see what this church had to say on the subject.

The teachers of the class that met the next Saturday morning were a married couple, Tim and Natalie Brooker, who both worked for the same Christian financial planning company. They surprised Penny when they said that the Bible had more than 2,300 verses about money and possessions. She grew a little uncomfortable when the topic turned to debt, but took advantage of the offer of a confidential session with the couple for later that afternoon.

When Penny met with the Brookers, she explained how she had hoped the seminar with Thom Handleman would introduce her to a way to generate income that would work for her. But Tim asked, "Did you check out his reputation before you took the advice to purchase the silver?"